



◁ Savoia-Marchetti SM79 "Sparviero" 1936

Origin Italy

Engine 3 x 1,000 hp Piaggio P.XI RC 40 air-cooled 14-cylinder radial

Top speed 286 mph (460 km/h)

Conceived as a fast, eight-passenger transport and for air racing, the "Sparrowhawk" made an ideal medium bomber, first in the Spanish Civil War and then as Italy's most effective torpedo bomber in WWII.



△ Messerschmitt Bf 109E 1938

Origin Germany

Engine 1,000 hp DB601A supercharged liquid-cooled inverted V12

Top speed 355 mph (572 km/h)

First flown in 1935, the all-metal Bf 109E was Germany's key fighter aircraft of its day. Tricky in takeoff, it was nevertheless light, fast, and agile in flight. Early models saw action in the Spanish Civil War.



◁ Gloster Gladiator 1936

Origin UK

Engine 830 hp Bristol Mercury IX air-cooled 9-cylinder radial

Top speed 255 mph (410 km/h)

Technically outdated, the Gladiator was the RAF's last biplane fighter in front-line service, including the 1940 siege of Malta. It was deployed by numerous other countries, such as China and Finland.



△ Supermarine Spitfire MK1a 1936

Origin UK

Engine 1,030-1,175 hp Rolls-Royce Merlin supercharged liquid-cooled V12

Top speed 360 mph (580 km/h)

R. J. Mitchell's Spitfire first flew in 1936. Subject to continuous development (20,351 were built in 13 main variants), it made a huge contribution to the Allied success in WWII.

▷ Westland Lysander 1936

Origin UK

Engine 810 hp Bristol Mercury XX supercharged air-cooled 9-cylinder radial

Top speed 212 mph (341 km/h)

The Lysander was used for WWII army operations, most famously to insert and recover agents in enemy-occupied territory, for which it would land in fields at night; 1,786 were built.



▷ Curtiss P-40 Warhawk 1938

Origin USA

Engine 1,040 hp Allison V-1710 supercharged liquid-cooled V12

Top speed 360 mph (580 km/h)

The Warhawk would be used by the air forces of 28 nations and was in service throughout WWII; 13,738 were built. Though not as fast as some, it was agile, durable, and cheap to build.

